



One Bin, Fewer Butts

Auditing a Smoking Shelter's Falling Butt Count Against an Independent Campus-Wide Sweep

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Background

Facilities consolidated outdoor smoking into one covered shelter last year, and the shelter's own monthly butt-collection count has fallen ever since. Does a shrinking count in the shelter's bin mean less campus smoking, or fewer bins anyone still empties?

Aims

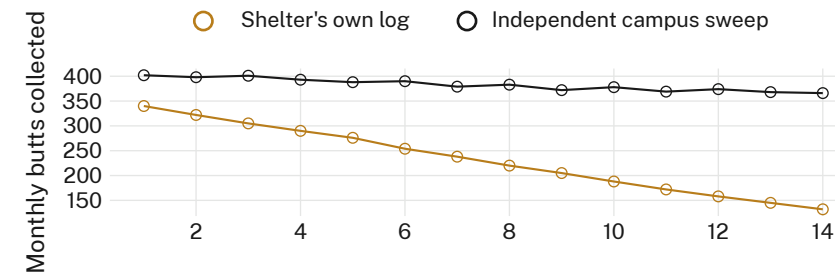
- Compare the shelter's own monthly collection count against an independent sweep of the six decommissioned outdoor points it replaced
- Test whether the shelter's decline tracks a campus-wide decline, or only its own convenience
- Establish what the consolidation metric has quietly stopped counting

Methods

- n = 1 shelter + 6 decommissioned outdoor points · monthly manual sweep · 14 months
- fixed-radius litter count, independent of the shelter's own bin-empty log
- sweep radius and timing pre-registered; no adjustment post hoc

Results

The shelter's own log shows collected butts falling from 340 to 132 a month (-61%). The independent sweep, covering the shelter and all six former points, falls only from 402 to 366 (-9%) over the same window.



Shelter log fell from 340 to 132 monthly butts between April 2025 and June 2026 (-61%); the independent campus-wide sweep fell only from 402 to 366 over the same window (-9%).

Discussion & conclusions

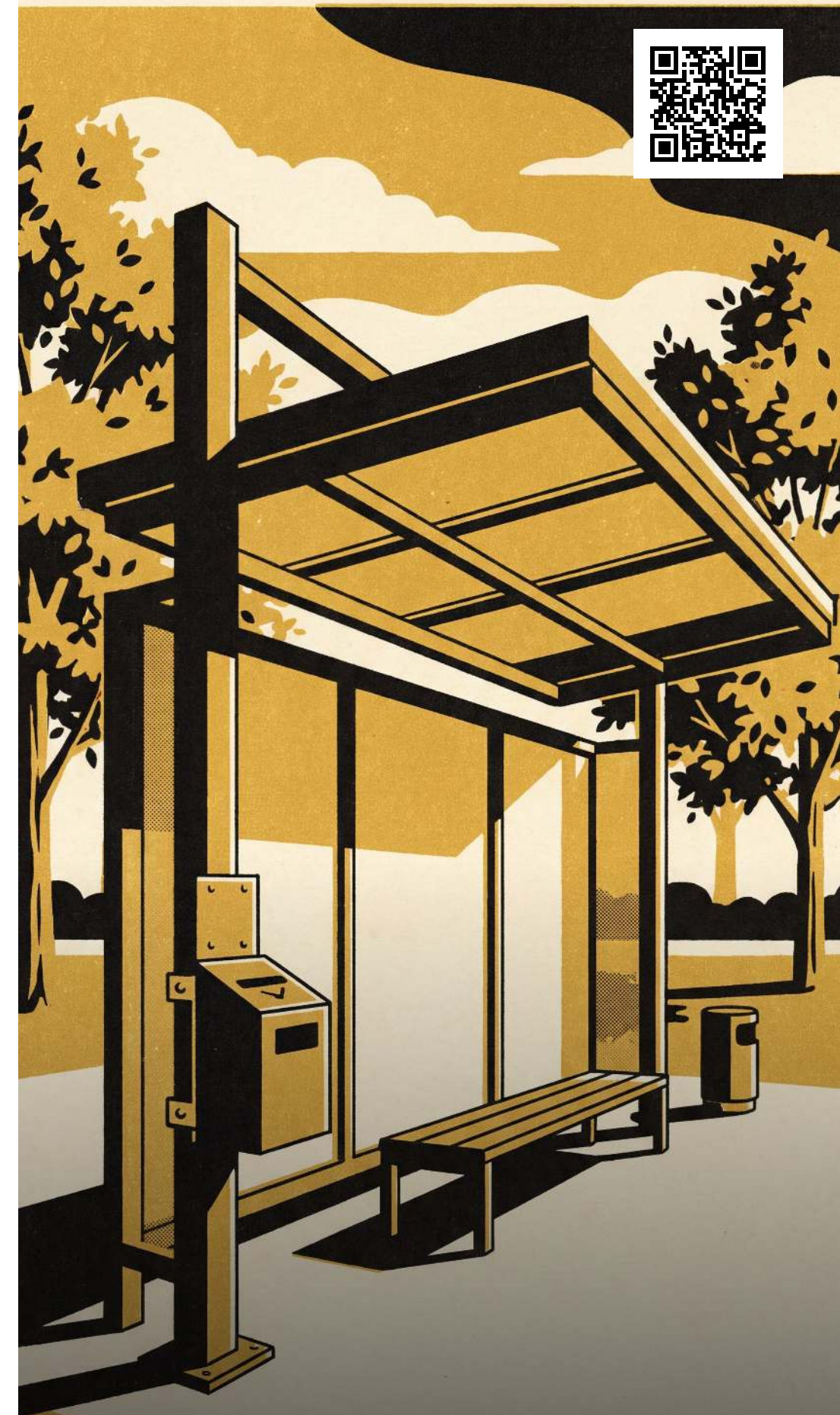
The shelter did not reduce campus smoking; it relocated where the evidence collects. A metric drawn from one convenient bin read as institutional progress against negligible change beyond it. Next: extend the independent sweep to the residential colleges before the shelter model is proposed there.

References

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Litter-sweep protocol pre-registered; no smoker was surveyed, approached, or photographed.

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“Butts fell 61% where we counted. 9% where we swept.”

Independent 14-month litter sweep across six decommissioned outdoor smoking points, Apr 2025–Jun 2026.